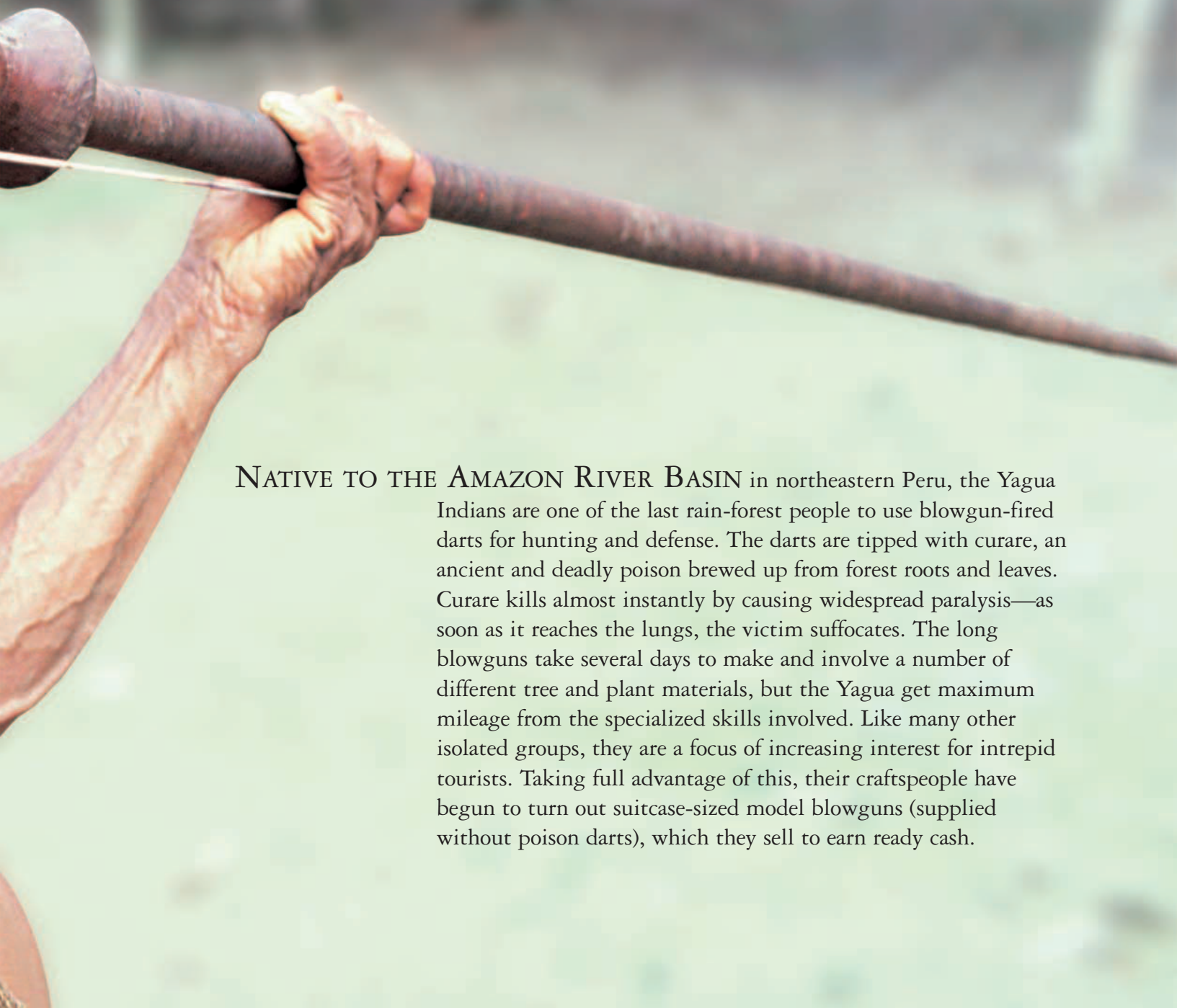




YAGUA

AIMING POISON DARTS



NATIVE TO THE AMAZON RIVER BASIN in northeastern Peru, the Yagua Indians are one of the last rain-forest people to use blowgun-fired darts for hunting and defense. The darts are tipped with curare, an ancient and deadly poison brewed up from forest roots and leaves. Curare kills almost instantly by causing widespread paralysis—as soon as it reaches the lungs, the victim suffocates. The long blowguns take several days to make and involve a number of different tree and plant materials, but the Yagua get maximum mileage from the specialized skills involved. Like many other isolated groups, they are a focus of increasing interest for intrepid tourists. Taking full advantage of this, their craftspeople have begun to turn out suitcase-sized model blowguns (supplied without poison darts), which they sell to earn ready cash.